

The Gamow Factor as Quantum Relative Entropy: Implications for Non-Equilibrium Screening in Fusion Plasmas

Sheng-Kai Huang^{1,*}

¹*Independent Researcher*

(Dated: March 28, 2026)

We identify an exact mathematical equivalence between the Gamow tunneling factor in nuclear fusion and the quantum relative entropy (QRE) of the Coulomb barrier viewed as a quantum channel. Specifically, the tunneling exponent $2\pi\eta$ equals the entropy production $\Sigma_{\text{barrier}} = -\ln(P_{\text{Gamow}})$ of the barrier channel, and the Petz recovery bound $F^2 \geq e^{-\Sigma}$ reproduces the Gamow transmission coefficient. This identification, while not altering the WKB tunneling exponent (which is state-independent), provides a thermodynamic framework for analyzing screening corrections. We derive a non-equilibrium screening correction using the quantum Crooks relation, and show that for ICF plasmas with non-Maxwellian velocity distributions (κ -distributions with $\kappa \sim 2\text{--}5$), the D-T reactivity is enhanced by 15–40% over equilibrium Maxwellian predictions. Static Debye screening contributes an additional $\sim 3\text{--}5\%$ at solar-core densities but is negligible ($< 0.1\%$) in laboratory plasmas. We also show that the temporal asymmetry $\tau = 1 - F$ of tunneling transitions from $\tau \approx 1$ (deep sub-barrier, fusion regime) to $\tau \approx 0$ (above barrier, classical regime), with $\tau = 1/2$ at $E_{1/2} \simeq 615\text{ keV}$ for D-T, providing a natural information-theoretic definition of the quantum-classical transition in nuclear reactions.

I. INTRODUCTION

Nuclear fusion in stars and laboratories depends on quantum tunneling through the Coulomb barrier between two positively charged nuclei. Since Gamow’s seminal calculation [1], the tunneling probability has been expressed as $P_{\text{Gamow}} \sim e^{-2\pi\eta}$, where $\eta = Z_1 Z_2 e^2 / (4\pi\epsilon_0 \hbar v)$ is the Sommerfeld parameter and v the relative velocity. The astrophysical S -factor formalism separates this Coulomb penetrability from nuclear-physics effects, enabling extrapolation of measured cross sections to stellar energies [2, 3].

In plasma environments, the bare Coulomb potential is screened by free electrons. The standard treatment employs the static Debye-Hückel potential [4], which enhances the reaction rate by a factor $f_D = e^{U_D/k_B T}$, where $U_D = Z_1 Z_2 e^2 / (4\pi\epsilon_0 \lambda_D)$ is the screening energy at the Debye radius. For stellar interiors this correction is a few percent [4, 5], while in laboratory plasmas at $T \gtrsim 5\text{ keV}$ it is negligible. Dynamic and quantum screening corrections have been studied by Ichimaru [6] and others, but a systematic framework for non-equilibrium plasmas—where $T_e \neq T_i$ and the velocity distribution may deviate strongly from Maxwellian—remains lacking.

In this work we provide such a framework by connecting the Gamow factor to the quantum relative entropy (QRE) formalism developed in Ref. [7]. In that framework the temporal asymmetry $\tau = 1 - F$ of any quantum channel $\mathcal{N}$ is bounded by the entropy production $\Sigma = D(\rho||\sigma)$ via the Petz recovery inequality $F^2 \geq e^{-\Sigma}$. We show that:

1. The Gamow tunneling exponent is *exactly* the entropy production of the Coulomb barrier channel:

$$\Sigma_{\text{barrier}} = 2\pi\eta \text{ (Sec. II).}$$

2. Entanglement between reactants cannot modify this exponent (Sec. III).
3. The Σ framework, combined with the quantum Crooks relation [8, 9], provides a natural language for non-equilibrium corrections; the dominant effect in ICF plasmas is the non-Maxwellian velocity distribution (Sec. IV).
4. Coupled-channels effects in heavy-ion fusion map to entanglement-assisted channel reduction of Σ (Sec. V).

The key new result is (iii): a quantitative prediction testable at the National Ignition Facility (NIF) and other inertial confinement fusion (ICF) experiments.

II. THE GAMOW-QRE IDENTIFICATION

A. Coulomb barrier as a quantum channel

Consider two nuclei with charges $Z_1 e$, $Z_2 e$ and reduced mass m approaching each other with center-of-mass kinetic energy E . The Coulomb potential is

$$V(r) = \frac{Z_1 Z_2 e^2}{4\pi\epsilon_0 r}, \quad (1)$$

with barrier height $V_C = V(R_N)$ at the nuclear radius $R_N \approx r_0(A_1^{1/3} + A_2^{1/3})$ with $r_0 \simeq 1.33\text{ fm}$. For $E < V_C$ the WKB tunneling probability through the barrier is [1]

$$P_{\text{Gamow}}(E) = e^{-2\pi\eta(E)}, \quad \eta(E) = \frac{Z_1 Z_2 e^2}{4\pi\epsilon_0 \hbar v} = \frac{Z_1 Z_2 \alpha}{\beta}, \quad (2)$$

* akai@fawstudio.com

where $v = \sqrt{2E/m}$, $\alpha \simeq 1/137.036$ is the fine-structure constant, and $\beta = v/c$.

We model the barrier traversal as a quantum channel $\mathcal{N}_{\text{barrier}}$ acting on the radial wave function. In the one-dimensional tunneling approximation, the incoming state $|\psi_{\text{in}}\rangle$ is mapped to

$$\mathcal{N}(|\psi_{\text{in}}\rangle\langle\psi_{\text{in}}|) = P_{\text{Gamow}} |T\rangle\langle T| + (1 - P_{\text{Gamow}}) |R\rangle\langle R|, \quad (3)$$

where $|T\rangle$ and $|R\rangle$ denote the transmitted and reflected components, respectively. This is an amplitude damping channel with damping parameter $\gamma = 1 - P_{\text{Gamow}}$.

B. Entropy production and the Petz bound

Theorem 1 (Gamow–QRE equivalence). *The entropy production of the Coulomb barrier channel satisfies*

$$\Sigma_{\text{barrier}}(E) \equiv -\ln[P_{\text{Gamow}}(E)] = 2\pi\eta(E). \quad (4)$$

The Petz recovery fidelity bound $F^2 \geq e^{-\Sigma}$ reproduces the Gamow factor:

$$F_{\text{Petz}}^2 \geq e^{-\Sigma_{\text{barrier}}} = e^{-2\pi\eta} = P_{\text{Gamow}}. \quad (5)$$

Proof. For an amplitude damping channel with transmission probability p , the input–output relative entropy evaluated between the incoming state $\rho = |1\rangle\langle 1|$ and the maximally mixed reference $\sigma = \frac{1}{2}\mathbb{I}$ is $D(\mathcal{N}(\rho)\|\mathcal{N}(\sigma)) = -\ln p$ (see, e.g., Ref. [10], Sec. 11.9). Identifying $p = P_{\text{Gamow}} = e^{-2\pi\eta}$ gives Eq. (4) directly. The Petz bound then follows from $F(\rho, \mathcal{R} \circ \mathcal{N}(\rho))^2 \geq e^{-D} = e^{-2\pi\eta} = P_{\text{Gamow}}$. $\square$

Remark.—The identification $\Sigma_{\text{barrier}} = 2\pi\eta$ is exact within the WKB approximation (which is itself excellent for $\eta \gtrsim 1$). For $\eta \lesssim 0.3$, where above-barrier reflections become important, one replaces P_{Gamow} by the full Coulomb penetration factor including the Sommerfeld correction [11].

C. Temporal asymmetry across the Coulomb barrier

The temporal asymmetry parameter [7]

$$\tau(E) = 1 - \sqrt{P_{\text{Gamow}}(E)} = 1 - e^{-\pi\eta(E)} \quad (6)$$

interpolates between $\tau = 1$ (fully irreversible, $E \rightarrow 0$) and $\tau = 0$ (fully reversible, $E \gg V_C$). The transition $\tau = 1/2$ occurs at the energy $E_{1/2}$ satisfying $P_{\text{Gamow}}(E_{1/2}) = 1/4$, i.e., $\eta(E_{1/2}) = \ln 2/\pi \simeq 0.2206$. For deuterium–tritium (D–T) fusion ($Z_1 = Z_2 = 1$, $m \simeq 1.21$ u, $R_N \simeq 3.6$ fm), we obtain

$$E_{1/2}^{\text{DT}} = \frac{m c^2}{2} \left(\frac{\alpha}{\eta_{1/2}} \right)^2 \simeq 615 \text{ keV}. \quad (7)$$

We call $E_{1/2}$ the *information-theoretic classical barrier*. The physical barrier height is $V_C \simeq e^2/(4\pi\epsilon_0 R_N) \simeq 400$ keV for D–T, so $E_{1/2} \approx 1.5 V_C$. Even at $E = V_C$ there is significant quantum reflection ($P_{\text{Gamow}} \simeq 14\%$, $\tau \simeq 0.62$), and full classical behavior requires E substantially above the barrier.

Table I lists τ for D–T at representative energies.

D. Physical interpretation

The mapping $2\pi\eta \leftrightarrow \Sigma_{\text{barrier}}$ assigns a thermodynamic entropy cost to Coulomb tunneling. Deep below the barrier ($\eta \gg 1$), the entropy production is large and recovery of the pre-barrier state is nearly impossible: $\tau \approx 1$. This corresponds to the fusion regime in stellar cores, where the solar p–p reaction operates at $\tau \approx 0.9999$ ($E \sim 6$ keV, $\eta \simeq 2.24$ for p–p). Fusion proceeds *because* the large entropy cost is paid by the exothermic nuclear reaction on the other side of the barrier.

At the Gamow peak energy $E_{\text{peak}} = (b_G k_B T/2)^{2/3}$, where $b_G = 2\pi\alpha\sqrt{m c^2/2} \simeq 34.4$ keV $^{1/2}$ for D–T, most fusion reactions occur. At $T = 10$ keV, $E_{\text{peak}} \simeq 31$ keV, giving $\tau \simeq 0.96$: still deeply quantum. Even at $T = 20$ keV ($E_{\text{peak}} \simeq 49$ keV), $\tau \simeq 0.91$. Above the barrier, $\tau \rightarrow 0$ and transmission becomes classically reversible.

III. WHAT ENTANGLEMENT CANNOT DO

A natural question arises: can quantum entanglement between the fusing nuclei reduce Σ_{barrier} and thereby enhance tunneling? We argue that it cannot, for three independent reasons.

1. *State-independence of the WKB exponent.*—The tunneling exponent $S_{\text{WKB}} = 2\int_{r_1}^{r_2} \kappa(r) dr$, where $\kappa = \sqrt{2m[V(r) - E]}/\hbar$ is the imaginary wave number, depends on the barrier shape $V(r)$ and the energy E , but *not* on the quantum state (superposition, entangled, or

TABLE I. Temporal asymmetry of the D–T Coulomb barrier. The Sommerfeld parameter is $\eta = \alpha\sqrt{m c^2/(2E)}$ with $m c^2 = 1127$ MeV. The Gamow peak energy is $E_{\text{peak}} \simeq 31$ keV at $T = 10$ keV.

E (keV)	η	Σ_{barrier} (nats)	P_{Gamow}	τ
1	5.47	34.4	1.2×10^{-15}	≈ 1.000
10	1.73	10.9	1.9×10^{-5}	0.996
31	0.98	6.18	2.1×10^{-3}	0.955
64	0.68	4.30	0.014	0.883
100	0.55	3.44	0.032	0.821
400	0.27	1.72	0.179	0.577
615	0.22	1.39	0.250	0.500
1000	0.17	1.09	0.337	0.419

mixed) of the incoming particle. The barrier is an external potential; entanglement between the two nuclei modifies their joint wave function but does not alter $V(r)$.

2. *Petz recovery restores the input, not the output.*—The Petz recovery map $\mathcal{R}$ is a channel that, given the post-barrier state, attempts to reconstruct the *pre-barrier* state. High Petz fidelity means one can recover the incoming wave packet from the reflected component. It does *not* mean one can enhance the transmission component. The bound $F^2 \geq e^{-\Sigma}$ states that recovery fidelity is bounded by the tunneling loss; saturating it does not increase the tunneling probability but merely certifies that no information is lost beyond Σ_{barrier} .

3. *Decoherence timescale.*—In a thermonuclear plasma at $T \sim 10$ keV ($\sim 10^8$ K), the Coulomb decoherence time for a deuteron at the Gamow peak energy is [12]

$$t_{\text{dec}} \sim \frac{\hbar}{k_B T} \frac{1}{n_e \sigma_C \lambda_{\text{th}}} \sim 10^{-19} \text{ s}, \quad (8)$$

where $n_e \sim 10^{25} \text{ m}^{-3}$, $\sigma_C \sim \pi a_0^2$, and λ_{th} is the thermal de Broglie wavelength. The tunneling time $t_{\text{tunnel}} \sim R_N/v \sim 10^{-21} \text{ s}$ is shorter, so entanglement between beam particles survives during a single tunneling event—but no mechanism exists for that entanglement to modify the barrier potential experienced by the tunneling particle.

We stress that this is not merely a practical limitation: entanglement can enhance *communication rates* through a channel (via superdense coding or entanglement-assisted capacity), but it does *not* increase the *channel's transmission probability* itself. The Coulomb barrier acts as an amplitude damping channel whose damping parameter is fixed by the external potential $V(r)$.

IV. NON-EQUILIBRIUM SCREENING

While entanglement cannot modify Σ_{barrier} for a given $V(r)$, the *effective* potential can differ from the bare Coulomb form in a plasma environment. Screening corrections reduce $V_{\text{eff}}(r)$ and hence Σ_{barrier} . The τ/Σ framework provides a natural language for analyzing these corrections, and in particular for decomposing the non-equilibrium effects in ICF plasmas into distinct Σ contributions.

A. Equilibrium Debye screening

In thermal equilibrium at temperature T with electron density n_e , the Debye-screened potential is

$$V_{\text{eff}}(r) = V(r) e^{-r/\lambda_D}, \quad \lambda_D = \sqrt{\frac{\varepsilon_0 k_B T}{n_e e^2}}. \quad (9)$$

The screening energy at the Debye radius is

$$U_D = \frac{Z_1 Z_2 e^2}{4\pi \varepsilon_0 \lambda_D}, \quad (10)$$

and the Salpeter screening enhancement is [4]

$$f_D = \exp\left(\frac{U_D}{k_B T}\right). \quad (11)$$

In the Σ language, screening reduces the barrier entropy by

$$\Delta \Sigma_{\text{barrier}}^{\text{Debye}} = -\frac{U_D}{k_B T}, \quad (12)$$

so $\Sigma_{\text{barrier}}^{\text{screened}} = \Sigma_{\text{barrier}}^{\text{bare}} + \Delta \Sigma_{\text{barrier}}^{\text{Debye}}$ and $f_D = e^{-\Delta \Sigma_{\text{barrier}}^{\text{Debye}}}$.

Numerical estimates.—For D-T at $T = 10$ keV, $n_e = 10^{25} \text{ m}^{-3}$ (typical of magnetic confinement): $\lambda_D \simeq 2.35 \times 10^{-7} \text{ m}$, $U_D \simeq 6 \times 10^{-3} \text{ eV}$, and $f_D \simeq 1 + 6 \times 10^{-7}$ (negligible). Static Debye screening is irrelevant for laboratory fusion.

For the solar core ($T \simeq 1.36$ keV, $n_e \simeq 6 \times 10^{31} \text{ m}^{-3}$): $\lambda_D \simeq 3.5 \times 10^{-11} \text{ m}$, $U_D \simeq 41 \text{ eV}$, $U_D/k_B T \simeq 0.030$, $f_D \simeq 1.030$ (3% enhancement, significant for solar neutrino predictions [13]). More refined treatments including quantum and dynamic corrections give $f_D \simeq 1.05$ for p-p in the solar center [6, 14].

B. Non-equilibrium effects in ICF: the Σ decomposition

In laser-driven ICF plasmas, three distinct non-equilibrium effects modify the fusion reactivity relative to an equilibrium Maxwellian plasma. The Σ framework allows a clean decomposition:

$$f_{\text{neq}}^{\text{total}} = f_D \times f_{2T} \times f_{\kappa}, \quad (13)$$

where f_D is the static Debye factor (negligible in the lab), f_{2T} is the two-temperature correction, and f_{κ} is the non-Maxwellian distribution correction. We now analyze each.

1. Two-temperature screening

The electron and ion temperatures are generically unequal in ICF: $T_e > T_i$ during the compression phase, with $T_e/T_i \sim 1.5$ –3 at NIF [15, 16]. The two-temperature Debye length is [6]

$$(\lambda_D^{(2T)})^{-2} = \frac{n_e e^2}{\varepsilon_0 k_B T_e} + \frac{n_i Z^2 e^2}{\varepsilon_0 k_B T_i}. \quad (14)$$

The quantum Crooks relation [8, 9] gives the entropy production for the screening process in a two-temperature system. The ions (at temperature T_i) tunnel through a barrier screened by the electron cloud (at T_e); the energy gained by the ion is $U_D^{(2T)}$. The ion-side entropy reduction is

$$\Delta \Sigma_{\text{neq}} = -\frac{U_D^{(2T)}}{k_B T_i}, \quad (15)$$

while the total entropy change including the electron side is

$$\Delta S_{\text{tot}} = \frac{U_D^{(2T)}}{k_B} \left(\frac{1}{T_e} - \frac{1}{T_i} \right) > 0 \quad \text{for } T_e > T_i, \quad (16)$$

consistent with the second law (heat flows from hot electrons to cold ions). The two-temperature screening enhancement is

$$f_{2T} = \exp\left(\frac{U_D^{(2T)}}{k_B T_i}\right) / \exp\left(\frac{U_D^{(\text{eq})}}{k_B T_i}\right), \quad (17)$$

where $U_D^{(\text{eq})}$ uses λ_D at $T = T_i$.

For NIF hot-spot conditions ($T_e \simeq 5$ keV, $T_i \simeq 3$ keV, $n_e \simeq 3 \times 10^{31} \text{ m}^{-3}$, corresponding to $\rho \sim 300 \text{ g/cm}^3$ DT fuel): $\lambda_D^{(2T)} \simeq 6.1 \times 10^{-11} \text{ m}$, $U_D^{(2T)} \simeq 24 \text{ eV}$, $U_D^{(2T)}/k_B T_i \simeq 0.008$. The two-temperature enhancement is $f_{2T} \simeq 1.008$, i.e., $\lesssim 1\%$.

Assessment.—Even at the extreme densities achieved during NIF stagnation, the static two-temperature Debye correction is of order 1%. This is because the coupling parameter $\Gamma = Z^2 e^2 / (4\pi\epsilon_0 a_{\text{WS}} k_B T_i)$ remains small ($\Gamma \sim 0.01$ at $T_i = 3$ keV), placing the plasma firmly in the weak-screening regime. The two-temperature Debye correction is *not* the dominant non-equilibrium effect.

2. Non-Maxwellian tail enhancement (dominant effect)

The *dominant* non-equilibrium correction in ICF plasmas arises from non-Maxwellian velocity distributions. Laser-plasma interactions, shock heating, and alpha-particle energy deposition generate suprathermal tails that are well parametrized by the κ -distribution [17, 18]:

$$f_\kappa(E) = C_\kappa \sqrt{E} \left(1 + \frac{E}{\kappa k_B T_i} \right)^{-(\kappa+1)}, \quad (18)$$

where C_κ is a normalization constant and $\kappa > 3/2$. As $\kappa \rightarrow \infty$, the Maxwellian distribution is recovered. For $\kappa \sim 2$ –5, the tail at $E \gg k_B T_i$ is substantially enhanced relative to a Maxwellian.

In the Σ framework, the fusion reactivity is

$$\langle \sigma v \rangle = \int_0^\infty \frac{S(E)}{E} e^{-\Sigma_{\text{barrier}}(E)} v(E) f(E) dE, \quad (19)$$

where $\sigma(E) = S(E) e^{-\Sigma_{\text{barrier}}(E)} / E$ with $S(E)$ the astrophysical S -factor. The key insight is that $\Sigma_{\text{barrier}}(E) = 2\pi\eta(E) = b_G / \sqrt{E}$ is a rapidly decreasing function of E , so particles in the suprathermal tail contribute disproportionately to the reactivity because they face a smaller Σ_{barrier} .

The κ -distribution enhancement factor is

$$f_\kappa \equiv \frac{\langle \sigma v \rangle_\kappa}{\langle \sigma v \rangle_{\text{MB}}} = \frac{\int_0^\infty \frac{S(E)}{E} e^{-\Sigma_{\text{barrier}}(E)} v f_\kappa(E) dE}{\int_0^\infty \frac{S(E)}{E} e^{-\Sigma_{\text{barrier}}(E)} v f_{\text{MB}}(E) dE}. \quad (20)$$

For nearly constant $S(E) \simeq S_0$ (a good approximation for D-T near the peak [19]), the integrals can be evaluated analytically in the saddle-point approximation. The Gamow peak energy shifts from $E_{\text{peak}}^{\text{MB}} = (b_G k_B T_i / 2)^{2/3}$ for a Maxwellian to a higher effective value for the κ -distribution, since the heavier tail weights higher energies.

We evaluate the ratio (20) numerically using the Gamow cross section $\sigma(E) = S_0 e^{-\Sigma_{\text{barrier}}(E)} / E$ with $S_0 \simeq 22 \text{ MeV}\cdot\text{b}$ for D-T [19], integrating up to $E = 1 \text{ MeV}$ (well above the Coulomb barrier, beyond which the Gamow approximation ceases to apply and the cross section decreases). The effective temperature of the κ -distribution is matched to T_i via $\theta = T_i(\kappa - 3/2)/\kappa$, ensuring $\langle E \rangle = 3T_i/2$ for all κ [20].

At $T_i = 10$ keV (NIF hot-spot peak burn):

$$f_{\kappa=5} \simeq 1.31 \quad (\text{moderate non-thermal}), \quad (21)$$

$$f_{\kappa=7} \simeq 1.21 \quad (\text{mild non-thermal}), \quad (22)$$

$$f_{\kappa=10} \simeq 1.14 \quad (\text{weakly non-thermal}). \quad (23)$$

At $T_i = 5$ keV (early compression):

$$f_{\kappa=5} \simeq 1.95, \quad f_{\kappa=10} \simeq 1.38, \quad f_{\kappa=20} \simeq 1.17. \quad (24)$$

The enhancement increases rapidly at lower T_i because the Gamow peak moves deeper into the distribution tail ($E_{\text{peak}}/k_B T_i \simeq 4.6$ at 3 keV vs. 3.1 at 10 keV), making the reactivity increasingly sensitive to suprathermal particles. For NIF-relevant conditions, $\kappa \sim 5$ –10 is expected in the hot spot during burn [18, 21], giving an enhancement of 15–40% depending on T_i and the degree of non-thermality.

C. Combined non-equilibrium enhancement

Combining the two-temperature screening and non-Maxwellian tail corrections, the total non-equilibrium enhancement for NIF-like conditions at $T_i \simeq 8$ –10 keV is

$$f_{\text{neq}}^{\text{total}} \simeq f_{2T} \times f_\kappa \simeq 1.01 \times (1.15\text{--}1.40) \simeq 1.15\text{--}1.40, \quad (25)$$

dominated by the f_κ contribution. We emphasize that the two-temperature Debye correction is subdominant ($\sim 1\%$); the 15–40% enhancement comes primarily from the non-Maxwellian distribution function.

The Σ framework makes this hierarchy transparent: the static screening shifts Σ_{barrier} by a small constant $\Delta\Sigma_{\text{barrier}} \sim 0.01$ for all energies, while the non-Maxwellian distribution changes the *weighting* of different Σ_{barrier} values, preferentially sampling the low- Σ_{barrier} tail. In information-theoretic terms, the κ -distribution concentrates the probability measure on trajectories with lower entropy production, i.e., those that tunnel more efficiently.

V. COUPLED CHANNELS AS INFORMATION CHANNELS

In heavy-ion fusion, the reaction cross section at sub-barrier energies significantly exceeds the prediction of single-channel tunneling calculations [22]. The coupled-channels formalism accounts for this by including couplings to excited states of the target and projectile nuclei (rotational, vibrational, and transfer channels), which effectively split the single barrier into a distribution of barriers [23, 24].

In the τ/Σ language, each coupled channel i has its own barrier entropy $\Sigma_{\text{barrier}}^{(i)}$, and the effective tunneling probability is

$$P_{\text{eff}} = \sum_i w_i e^{-\Sigma_{\text{barrier}}^{(i)}}, \quad (26)$$

where w_i are the channel weights. By Jensen's inequality,

$$\Sigma_{\text{eff}} = -\ln P_{\text{eff}} \leq \sum_i w_i \Sigma_{\text{barrier}}^{(i)} = \bar{\Sigma}, \quad (27)$$

so the effective entropy production is always *less than* the weighted average of individual-channel entropies. This is the information-theoretic origin of the sub-barrier enhancement in heavy-ion fusion: channel coupling provides additional “paths” through the barrier, reducing the effective Σ .

The analogy to entanglement-assisted quantum communication is precise: in quantum information theory, entanglement between sender and receiver can increase the channel capacity beyond the unassisted value. Here, the “entanglement” is the coupling between relative motion and internal nuclear degrees of freedom, and the “capacity” is the tunneling probability. Crucially, this is *not* entanglement between the two fusing nuclei (which we argued cannot help in Sec. III), but entanglement between the tunneling coordinate and internal excitations—a qualitatively different mechanism that modifies the *effective potential* via channel coupling.

VI. EXPERIMENTAL PREDICTIONS

The τ/Σ framework makes the following testable predictions:

1. *Non-equilibrium reactivity in ICF.*—The non-Maxwellian enhancement f_κ [Eq. (23)] predicts a 15–40% increase in D-T reactivity at $T_i \sim 8$ –10 keV with $\kappa \sim 5$ –10. This is testable by comparing NIF neutron yield during early compression (when $T_e \gg T_i$ and suprathermal tails are strongest) with simulations using equilibrium vs. non-equilibrium distribution functions. The NIF diagnostic suite includes neutron time-of-flight and neutron imaging that can temporally resolve the burn history [25]. The Σ framework predicts that the enhancement should correlate with the degree of non-thermality (measurable

via Thomson scattering [26]): plasmas with lower effective κ should show systematically higher yields.

2. *Information-theoretic classical barrier.*—The energy $E_{1/2} \simeq 615$ keV for D-T [Eq. (7)] is the energy at which $\tau = 1/2$ —the information-theoretic quantum-classical transition. For other systems: p-p: $E_{1/2} \simeq 1.1$ MeV; $^{12}\text{C}+^{12}\text{C}$: $E_{1/2} \simeq 15$ MeV. Beam-target experiments at variable energy can map $\tau(E)$ by measuring the transmission coefficient and comparing with $1-\tau = e^{-\pi\eta}$.

3. *Fusion product correlations.*—The D-T reaction $^2\text{H}+^3\text{H} \rightarrow ^4\text{He}(3.5 \text{ MeV})+n(14.1 \text{ MeV})$ produces an n - ^4He pair whose angular correlations encode the reaction mechanism. The τ of the *output* channel (from compound nucleus to separated products) satisfies $\tau^{\text{out}} \approx 0$, since the Q-value of 17.6 MeV places the products far above any Coulomb barrier. This predicts strong angular correlations measurable via coincidence detection.

VII. DISCUSSION

We have established an exact identification between the Gamow tunneling exponent and the quantum relative entropy of the Coulomb barrier channel. We are explicit about what is new and what is interpretive.

Interpretive (no new physics): The Gamow-QRE identification $\Sigma_{\text{barrier}} = 2\pi\eta$ recasts the 1928 WKB result in information-theoretic language. The τ parameter provides a natural quantum-classical interpolation, but does not predict new tunneling phenomena. The equilibrium Debye screening, when expressed as $\Delta\Sigma_{\text{barrier}} = -U_D/k_B T$, recovers the Salpeter result exactly.

New predictions: (i) The non-Maxwellian tail enhancement, expressed in the Σ framework as preferential sampling of low- Σ_{barrier} trajectories, gives a quantitative prediction [Eq. (23)] testable at NIF. While the κ -distribution reactivity enhancement itself has been studied [20, 27], the Σ framework provides a unified entropy-production language that connects it to the two-temperature screening and coupled-channels effects within a single formalism. (ii) The coupled-channels Σ -reduction via Jensen's inequality [Eq. (27)] gives a new information-theoretic interpretation of sub-barrier heavy-ion fusion enhancement. (iii) The information-theoretic classical barrier $E_{1/2}$ provides a system-independent definition of where quantum tunneling gives way to classical over-barrier transmission.

The connection to our companion work on superconductivity [28] is worth noting: both superconductivity ($\tau = 0$ for Cooper pair transport) and fusion ($\tau \rightarrow 1$ for sub-barrier tunneling) are extreme limits of the same τ spectrum. A room-temperature superconducting magnet would directly benefit fusion reactor design [29], connecting the two applications of the τ framework.

We emphasize an important honesty condition: static Debye screening is negligible ($< 0.1\%$) in laboratory fusion plasmas at keV temperatures and $n_e \lesssim 10^{26} \text{ m}^{-3}$. The 15–40% non-equilibrium enhancement we predict

comes *overwhelmingly* from non-Maxwellian velocity distributions, not from modifications to the screened potential. The Σ framework makes this hierarchy manifest.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

This work is part of the τ/Σ unification program. The author thanks the NIF team for making their experimen-

tal parameters publicly available.

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